KAPASA MAKASA UNIVERSITY

ADDITIONAL APICULTURE NOTES (2025)

TOPIC: CAPTURING, TRAPPING AND HIVING OF SWARMS AND/OR COLONIES

Generally the rate of swarms occupying modern top bar hives is lower than in traditional hives. Therefore bees sometimes may have to be trapped or captured and introduced into the top bar hives if the hives are unoccupied for a long time. Bee swarms should be captured and introduced only between the beginning and peak of the nectar flows, otherwise they may note settle easily and may abscond (abandon the hive) if they are captured and introduced outside this recommended period. So for the best time please refer to the bee calendar.

Tools and materials required when capturing bees

When going out to capture bee swarms, the following tools and materials are required; a smoker, catching boxes, enough smoking material, knife, feather/bee brush, protective clothing, queen excluder and an axe.

Procedure for capturing a colony on the ground or in the tree

Step 1: First make a fire to prepare the smoking material. Fill the smoker wit burning charcoal and the smoking material.

Step 2: Put on the protective clothing and smoke your clothing and face and have all the required tools ready.

Step 3:

Next, smoke the colony thoroughly. The smoke helps to make the beekeeping go smoothly.

Step 4:

You dig if the bees are in the ground or cut or chop if the bees are in the tree trunk near the entrance hole so that you can see the combs. When you have accessed the combs, put the brood combs in one box and the honey combs in the other box. Put the box with the brood combs near the original nest and the flying bees will fly into the box and start covering the brood.

Step 5:

Smoke the bees in the box and search for the queen and put her in the queen cage or matchbox once captured. It must be stated here that the work of searching and capturing the queen is time consuming and this procedure requires the skill of identifying the queen. Seal the catch box and take the bees to the apiary for hiving. In the absence of the queen cage you simply brush the bees into the hive with queen excluders on the entrance of the holes. Money or paper clips with an inner measurement of 4mm can be used as queen excluders.

Step 6:

Hiving the swarm. Tie the queen cage on the middle top bar. Put the queen excluders or money or paper clips on the entrance holes of the hive. Release the queen after two weeks. Remove the queen excluder or money or paper clips after a week.

Procedure for capturing a swarm hanging in the tree.

Step 1 and 2: Refer to previous arrangement

Step 3:

Smoke gently and repeatedly over the swarm without arousing it

Step 4:

Shake and brush the bees into an empty catch box. If most of the bees have fallen into the catch box, you can almost be certain that you got the queen. Search for the queen and put her in the queen cage or matchbox.

Step 5

Same as step 6 above

Trapping swarms using swarm boxes

Bees can also be trapped or obtained using swarm or trap boxes. A swarm box is a short top bar hive with the same width measurement, but only covered with about 8-12 top bars. It should have n entrance slit of about 5cm long and 1cm high. The swarm box has to be baited and sited during the swarming period.

Procedure

Step 1:

To prepare the swarm box, smear the inside of the swarm box entrance and top bars with beeswax or propolis. Bait the top bars correctly in the groove.

Step 2:

Place or hang the swarm box high in the trees or roof tops to easily capture the swarms. Frequently monitor the swarm box for occupation.

Step 3:

After 3 or 4 weeks from occupation date, transfer the trapped swarm into the top bar hive. Transfer the top bars with combs into the main top bar hive and remember to keep the combs in the same order. Smoke and brush the remaining bees into the your top bar hive.

Step 4:

After transferring the colony to the hive, re-site the swarm box for more colony capture.